

	Division/Section	Family Support
	Chapter No./Name	4 – Economic Stability (ES)
	Part No./Name	P – Strategies to Empower People (STEP) Program
	Section No./Name	P-300- STEP Case Management Process
	Document No./Name	P-320-STEP Home Visits
	Effective Date	August 15, 2022

I. STATEMENT OF POLICY

Home visiting programs are intended to support families in providing an atmosphere that promotes the healthy progression and development of the family. STEP's objective is to target services to families and caregivers to improve outcomes, and promote a positive recipient-agency interaction.

Although home visiting programs differ in their approach, published documentation has acknowledged that populations served by a home visit display positive outcomes. High-quality home visiting programs provide family support services that reduce risks and increase beneficial results.

A home visit should have a purpose and desired outcome. STEP's intent is to provide support to high-risk families with multiple challenges and levels of difficulty. Take this opportunity to listen and allow the participants to share their story.

Why is a home visit beneficial?

- **Participants stay in their comfort zone.** Meeting in an agency office can be intimidating and talking over the phone can be distancing and impersonal. By having a STEP Coach travel to a STEP's recipient's home, participants may be more likely to voice their concerns, speak candidly, and allow the STEP Coach into their lives.
- **Closer partnerships, positive communication.** Many times when a STEP Coach contacts a participant, it is regarding an issue with low participation. Home visits give participants and their STEP Coaches the opportunity to meet simply to talk and collaborate for the benefit of the participant and their family.
 - In-person meetings break the "cycle of blame." Especially with low-performing STEP recipients, participants and STEP Coaches can begin to blame each other for the failings of the family. Home visits help to put a human face to a name and turn finger pointing into teamwork and understanding.
- **The STEP Coach learns more about their participant's family.** Research indicates that the biggest benefit of a home visit is to gain a better understanding of a recipient's environment and how that environment might affect a STEP family.
- **Participants realize they have a network of support.** Participants take comfort in knowing that they have someone vested into the success of their family who understands their home situation.
- **Participants are more likely to [become involved](#).** When participants are more familiar with their STEP Coach, they are more likely to become involved with STEP and more involved in their program activities and [volunteering](#). In this way, a few well-placed home visits can facilitate positive outcomes for all invested in the family unit.

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Show your dedication to their success. What message do you send when you show up at their door telling them that you noticed they were not at their assigned site? You are letting the participant know that you care enough to come to them and understand their challenges.

II. PROCEDURES

P-321-STEP - PR CONDUCTING A HOME VISIT

There are proactive steps that STEP Coaches can take to create a sense of structure, consistency, predictability, safety, and hope in their interactions with customers.

While services are delivered in the home of participating families within their ongoing daily routines and activities, safety and respect is at the forefront for all. It is possible that you will go into unfamiliar neighborhoods, entering homes in which not all family members welcome your visit, or entering into apartments or housing developments where you are not welcome. Home visits should occur with the consent of the participant and be scheduled with the appropriate notice.

Human service staff, by the very nature of their job duties, are often placed in the middle of highly volatile situations and therefore it is highly recommended that staff adhere to policy, [15. Safety and Loss Prevention Part No./Name 5. Office Safety Section No./Name 15-530 Threats to Staff or Agency.](#)

P-322-STEP - PR INTERVIEWING TECHNIQUES

Tailor your questions to fit the type of information you need. Encourage STEP recipients' participation by asking open-ended questions. Use the Goal 4It! Model and motivational interviewing to help the participant to understand their own ideas, interests, and solutions.

P-323-STEP - PR SUPERVISOR AWARENESS

Supervisor approval must be received in advance prior to traveling to conduct off-site visits.

It is recommended to travel in teams or pairs. Supervisors are to ensure there is a “buddy system” in place when at all possible; such as, another STEP Coach or non-traditional employee (i.e. intern).

Where pairing with a team member is not possible: The STEP Coach must discuss with their supervisor and/or manager the reason for the home visit. The discussion shall include a planned date and time. Upon approval, the STEP Coach will check-in with their supervisor before leaving, provide an anticipated return time and check-in again upon return.

Staff must create a plan for home visits and submit to their supervisor for approval prior to conducting a home visit. Home visit results must be documented in the record. The [STEP 1](#) can be used for this purpose. The approved [STEP 1](#) form is to be kept in a supervisor file for audit and tracking purposes.

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P-324-STEP - PR DOCUMENTING VISITS

Upon returning to the agency staff are to record the results of the visit in LITE on the *Person Notes* screen.

P-325-STEP - PR STAFF REPORTING RESPONSIBILITIES

All DCFS staff are mandated reporters. Whenever child abuse/neglect is observed or suspected by DCFS staff within their assigned job responsibilities or staff becomes aware, whether working for the department or while off duty, it shall be immediately reported in accordance with policy reference, 4-105 Legal Basis for Report and Investigation or Assessment. Refer to DSS Policy Manual, part 5, Legal; Section 6-04, Reporting Suspected Abuse, Neglect or Exploitation of Children if staff have cause to believe that a child's physical, mental, or emotional health and safety are endangered as a result of abuse or neglect.

The following steps must be adhered to:

- Staff are to immediately report to the DCFS Centralized Intake Child Abuse Reporting Hotline any suspected child abuse/neglect
- Staff shall not screen the information prior to making the report nor conduct a preliminary investigation unless assigned to do so as a result of the intake process.
- The reporting worker shall document the report information in any case record within his own caseload when the alleged victim is in his caseload.
 - Document the specifics of what they witnessed or learned from the participant or the outside party about the alleged abuse/neglect.
- The worker shall advise his supervisor of the report.

III. FORMS AND INSTRUCTIONS

[STEP 1 Form](#) / [Instructions](#) STEP Home Visit Log/Documentation

IV. REFERENCES

[LAC 67: XVI Subpart 16. Strategies to Empower People \(STEP\) Program, Chapter 57, Subchapter CSTEP Program Process, 5719 and 5725](#)